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Tourist Gaze

The tourist gaze refers to the idea that tourists' ways of seeing places and people and the selection of those sights is directed and organised by the tourism industry.

In 1990, sociologist John Urry published a book entitled *The Tourist Gaze* which has subsequently become a highly influential text within the study of tourism. Urry took the concept of 'the gaze', which was developed by French theorists Jacques Lacan and Michel Foucault in the 1960s, and applied it to the field of tourism. In his work, he emphasises the visual nature of tourism – the way in which tourists seek out and consume visual images and the means by which the tourism industry organises and directs this consumption. At a basic level, tourism's visual characteristics will come as no surprise to readers. Tourists take photographs and buy picture postcards of the places they visit, book window seats on trains, ascend high buildings to appreciate views – indeed, 'sightseeing' is synonymous with tourism and has been since its earliest days. What is interesting about Urry's concept of the tourist gaze is not simply the revelation that tourists like to look at sights, but that the sights they consume are selected, constructed, stage-managed and directed by an increasingly influential tourism industry. Examples of the various equipment and structures created specifically to direct the tourist gaze include pleasure piers and promenades in seaside resorts, hotel balconies and terraces, scenic viewpoints in national parks and the extensive tourism media incorporating guidebooks, postcards, websites and travel programmes.

The construction of the tourist gaze is not a new phenomenon, as Urry explains. When scholastic or scientific travel gave way to the tourism of the Picturesque in the eighteenth century, early European tourists were keen to experience and collect the views described in illustrated guidebooks and many captured these sights for themselves in sketchbooks. The Picturesque way of seeing was to view the world as a series of framed pictures, as if the viewer was in a gallery. The Picturesque gaze prefigured our contemporary tourist gaze, organised around constructed images found in holiday brochures, television programmes and on websites. These images inform visitors about what to look at and, importantly, what to avoid. As Urry says, the tourist gaze does not often include images of 'waste, disease, dead animals, poverty, sewage and despoilation' (Urry, 1990/2002: 129). The sights deemed suitable for the tourist gaze are endlessly reproduced through the tourists' own photographs, which are then recirculated among the tourists' family and friends. Urry acknowledges the importance of photography to the construction of the tourist gaze and indeed to the development of tourism itself – photography and tourism 'each derives from and enhances the other' (1990/2002: 129).

Urry sets out the basic conditions that produce a distinctive 'tourist gaze'. In order for someone to gaze upon something with the regard of a tourist, there must first be a distinction

between what is considered an ordinary everyday experience and that which is extraordinary. Potential objects of the tourist gaze must be different from those experiences at home. These objects may be:

- unique objects (such as the Eiffel Tower, or the Grand Canyon)
- particular tourism 'signs' such as a typical English village or a quintessential French chateau
- unfamiliar aspects of that which is familiar (such as museum settings of the lives of historical communities)
- ordinary aspects of life seen in unusual contexts (tourists gazing on locals carrying out domestic tasks under political regimes different from their own)
- familiar tasks (shopping, eating, swimming) undertaken against unusual visual backgrounds
- signs that indicate that a seemingly everyday object is in fact extraordinary (for example, an interpretation board that indicates that an ordinary looking field may have been the site of a decisive battle or event).

As can be seen from the above, people can be an object of the gaze as much as can the natural or built environment, but they too must embody a sense of the 'other' to merit attention. This quality of being 'other' to the tourist might derive from a perceived **authenticity** or exoticism – for example, the tourist may wish to gaze upon local people wearing colourful national costume or carrying out traditional rituals.

The tourist gaze can be experienced within different social contexts appropriate to the nature of the objects viewed. Urry terms the individual, solitary view the 'romantic gaze', where a proper appreciation of a work of art or a lonely mountain scene can only take place if one is alone in contemplation. On the other hand, what Urry calls the 'collective gaze' is levelled at sights and events where crowds of fellow-gazers add to the experience, for example, at a theme park or an event such as the Notting Hill Carnival in London.

As tourism becomes increasingly globalised, the range of objects of the gaze widens; for example, **dark tourism** sites, remote landscapes and adventurous destinations have all become popular in recent years. As more parts of the world become tourism destinations, so the tourism industry develops 'systematic, regularized and evaluative procedures that enable each place to monitor, modify and maximize their location within the turbulent global order' (Urry, 1990/2002: 142). Moreover, the nature of the gazer diversifies as economic and political change opens up travel for more of the world's population. In his second edition of *The Tourist Gaze*, published in 2002, Urry acknowledges these global changes and also addresses some of the criticisms that his 1990 edition prompted. The bulk of these critiques revolve around the notion that in privileging the visual, the other four senses, so important to tourism, have been denied. Tourism, it is argued, is as much about bodily performance, smelling, hearing, touching and tasting as it is about the simple visual appropriation of place. Urry counters the argument that a single tourist gaze is too simplistic to convey the experience of contemporary global tourism by re-asserting the 'awesome dominance of the visual' (1990/2002: 149). However, he does concede that as we become increasingly mobile, experiencing more of the world through

sight, sound, touch, smell and taste, the tourist gaze becomes increasingly embodied and omnipresent. Perhaps the prevalence of the tourist gaze in every aspect of our lives means that ‘there can be no effective study of “tourism” *per se* as the tourist gaze is simply everywhere and in a kind of way nowhere in particular’ (1990/2002: 145).

Despite the critiques outlined above, Urry’s *The Tourist Gaze* remains a compelling and influential work as can be seen from the following recent tourism journal articles that utilise and further develop the concept of the gaze.

‘The Beach, the gaze and film tourism’ (L. Law, T. Bunnell and C. Ong (2007) *Tourist Studies*)

Using the film *The Beach* (based on Alex Garland’s book of the same title), this article explores the role of the tourist gaze in **film tourism** and examines how such a gaze can impact on tourist practices in the destination itself as film-viewers seek out their own beach.

‘The family gaze’ (M. Haldrup and J. Larsen (2003) *Tourist Studies*)

This article takes the concept of the tourist gaze and applies it to tourists’ photography practice. The authors argue that although photography allows the visual consumption of places, it also has an important role in producing social relations as many photographs record the performing family rather than the material world.

‘The mutual gaze’ (D. Maoz (2006) *Annals of Tourism Research*)

This explores the ideas that tourists gaze upon locals but that this is a mutual gaze, as the native population hold their own stereotypical ideas about tourists which shape the way they look upon them.

‘Gazing the hood: hip-hop as tourism attraction’ (P. Xie, H. Osumare and A. Ibrahim (2007) *Tourism Management*)

Exploring the emerging phenomenon of hip-hop tourism in the USA, this article suggests that hip-hop can be viewed through a sequence of three tourist gazes – the *initial gaze* (relating to curiosity and voyeurism), the *mass gaze* (as the cultural form becomes commodified and globalised) and finally the *authentic gaze* (hip-hop sought out as special interest tourism).

See also: *authenticity, post-tourism*

FURTHER READING

Clearly, the 1990 and 2002 editions of *The Tourist Gaze* are to be recommended to readers, who may also be interested in following some of the ensuing debate on Urry’s work, for example in MacCannell’s ‘Tourist agency’ in *Tourist Studies* and in Franklin’s ‘The Tourist Gaze and beyond: an interview with John Urry’, also in *Tourist Studies*.

RECOMMENDED BOOKS AND ARTICLES

- Franklin, A. (2001) 'The Tourist Gaze and beyond: an interview with John Urry', *Tourist Studies*, 1 (2): 115–31.
- MacCannell, D. (2001) 'Tourist Agency', *Tourist Studies*, 1: 2–37.
- Urry, J. (1990/2002) *The Tourist Gaze: Leisure and Travel in Contemporary Societies*. London: Sage.

Post-tourism

The post-tourist or Postmodern tourist is a consumer who embraces openly, but with some irony, the increasingly inauthentic, commercialised and simulated experiences offered by the tourism industry.

The concept of the post-tourist has developed in response to consumer attitudes and preferences in the Postmodern era. The term seems to have been coined by Feifer (1985), and has been used subsequently by Urry (1990/2002), Rojek (1997) and others. The Postmodern world is characterised by globalisation, hyper-consumerism, the **experience economy** and new developments in technology. Consumers have numerous choices and possibilities, and often undertake seemingly incompatible activities simultaneously in order to capitalise on this array of opportunities. Postmodern tourism has therefore been described as a form of ‘pastiche tourism’ (Hollinshead, 1997: 192) or ‘collage tourism’ (Rojek, 1997: 62).

According to a report by Tyrell and Mai (2001), experiences and memories now mean more to contemporary consumers than products, and they emphasise the need for innovative approaches to development, which satisfy the needs of individualistic ‘money rich/time poor’ consumers. Their report builds on the work of Pine and Gilmore (1999), who discuss the **experience economy**, in which businesses compete to create unique and memorable experiences for customers. Post-tourists are likely to be responsive to experience-creation, and often the more fantastical the better. They are familiar with new technology and are especially responsive to media. The profile of the Postmodern tourist is discussed by both Urry (1990/2002) and Walsh (1992). They describe how many Postmodern consumers receive much of their travel knowledge through media representations. They cite Feifer (1985) who described the post-tourist as one who does not even have to leave the house in order to view the typical objects of the **tourist gaze**. The simulated tourist experience is brought into their living rooms through television travel shows, internet sites and software programmes.

Post-tourists have very different views and expectations from more conventional or traditional tourists, e.g. cultural tourists. For the post-tourist, tourism has become playful: ‘the post-tourist knows that they are a tourist and that tourism is a game or a series of games with multiple texts and no single, authentic tourist experience’ (Urry, 1990/2002: 100). Post-tourists accept multiple interpretations of history and culture, and do not see the need to differentiate between ‘high’ and ‘low’ culture, embracing contemporary, popular culture (e.g. pop music, theme parks) as much as traditional or folk cultures. They also do not always make a distinction between reality and fiction, mainly due to the growth in simulated experiences, virtual reality and the creation of fantasy experiences. Post-tourists recognise the fact that culture is often contrived and inauthentic, and may wholeheartedly embrace inauthentic experiences, being drawn to ‘hyper-real’ attractions (e.g. theme parks, leisure centres or

shopping malls), simulacra (e.g. Santa Claus' Lapland), or, as described by AlSayyad (2001), sites of 'authentic fakery' such as Las Vegas or manufactured heritage theme parks of 'fake authenticity'. Kirschenblatt-Gimblett (1998: 9) suggests that the Postmodern world has become a kind of museum of itself: 'Tourists travel to actual destinations to experience virtual places.'

Rojek (1993) described the post-tourist as having three main characteristics. These are:

- an awareness of the commodification of the tourist experience, which the post-tourist treats playfully
- the attraction to experience as an end in itself, rather than the pursuit of self-improvement through travel
- the acceptance that the representations of the tourist site are as important as the site itself.

This means that the post-tourist can freely enjoy the escapism afforded by tourism and the diversity of entertaining experiences. He or she may also take as much pleasure in a replica monument or a visual representation of a site as in the site itself.

Rojek (1993) also suggests four kinds of tourist site which tend to feature in the landscape of Postmodernism and are visited by post-tourists:

- blackspots (the commercial development of sites of atrocity, such as graves, war zones, massacre, assassination or accident sites)
- heritage sites (these are not always authentic in their interpretation of the past, instead offering a sanitised, glorified or entertaining version of history)
- literary landscapes (e.g. places which have become famous because they feature in an author's works, but which are often fictional)
- theme parks (these combine all aspects of global culture, new technology and media).

Smith (2005) refers to one form of post-tourist, and that is the 'new leisure tourist'. It is suggested that this is a relatively young breed of tourist, who is seeking escapism, entertainment and fun. Disposable income levels are relatively high but time is generally short. Although comfort and security are sought, the tourism experience should afford an element of excitement or thrill. This might be in the safe confines of a hotel, resort or themed attraction. Typical attractions might include visiting adventure lands, cyber worlds or simulated environments. New leisure tourists enjoy landscapes that correspond to Barber's (1995) concept of 'McWorld', where a number of familiar global brands are clustered under one roof. It is of no consequence that such attractions could be located anywhere, it is the experiences gained which count. The new leisure tourist differs significantly from traditional visitors like cultural tourists. There is no pretension of being interested in local societies and cultures; instead, simulated environments may be preferred. For example, many theme parks simulate environments like Egypt's Valley of the Kings, an Arabic souk or the jungles of Africa, without the inconvenience of further travel, and offer 'safer' experiences there.

There is clearly a considerable difference between the profiles and motivations of different types of tourists. For example, whereas cultural tourists are actively seeking authentic cultural experiences and interaction with local people, post-tourists tend to enjoy more simulated experiences, believing that truly authentic places and cultures are impossible to find. When it

comes to new leisure tourists, they are actively looking for fake authenticity and simulated worlds. They simply want to have fun and be entertained, whereas cultural tourists may be on an educational or self-development quest. Post-tourists and new leisure tourists are positively playful in their approach and may not easily distinguish between fantasy and reality. They may be unaware of, and would certainly not be offended by, commercialisation.

It is debatable as to how far the concept of the post-tourist is typical of the modern era, and to what extent it is merely lifestyle or life-stage-driven. Tourist profiles are never fixed or static, and people may choose to be a cultural tourist at one time and a post-tourist or new leisure tourist at another. For example, single people and childless couples may be more likely to pursue cultural activities than families with young children or teenagers, who often seek out post-tourism attractions. At certain points in time, people might prefer to seek escapism, entertainment and fun than education (e.g. when life and work have become particularly stressful). Thus, post-tourism is also driven by life-stage and mood, and typologies can only indicate collective trends rather than individual preferences and proclivities. A profile of the post-tourist is therefore tentatively offered in the box below.

Typical Profile of a Post-Tourist

- Relatively young (18–45 years)
- High disposable income
- Compulsive consumer
- Time pressured
- Individualistic/independent
- Escapist on holiday but work-obsessed at home
- More interested in entertainment than education or self-development
- Experience-collector
- Enjoys luxury, comfort, security
- A thrill-seeker but in a controlled environment
- Short attention span
- Interested in new technology and media
- Fascinated by the cult of celebrity

(Adapted from Smith, 2005)

It is clear that post-tourism is dominated by consumers who are short of time but keen to engage in as many activities as possible in order to maximise their precious leisure experiences. Their high disposable incomes allow them to take more and more holidays, and to be more discerning and demanding in their tastes. Consequently, the desire for comfort, luxury and quality of service is paramount, but so too is the need for escapism, entertainment and fun. Post-consumers are clearly keen to leave home and the demands of work behind, but

destinations are required to become more and more sophisticated and exciting in order to attract them. Therefore, fantastical tourism projects are being developed as a means of differentiating and branding destinations in a competitive marketplace. Attractions which are typically visited by the post-tourist are listed in the box below.

Typical Post-Tourist Destinations

- Postmodern, cosmopolitan cities like Los Angeles
- Fantastical destinations like Las Vegas or Dubai
- Theme Parks
- Fantasy attractions (e.g. Santa Claus Land)
- Film and TV studios or settings
- 'McWorlds' or global entertainment zones (e.g. mega shopping malls)

Future post-tourists are likely to be older, with even more time and money on their hands. As everyone becomes more technologically literate and media-orientated, it will be interesting to see how the attractions sector responds. Although there have been many debates about the sustainability of destinations like Dubai, which have been criticised for being environmentally unfriendly or for employing slave labour, these man-made, simulated and virtual environments are the least vulnerable to the impacts of mass tourism. Therefore, perhaps ironically, unreal and inauthentic post-tourism destinations may offer the most sustainable form of tourism development in the future!

See also: *experience economy, tourist gaze*

FURTHER READING

There are no books specifically on the concept of the post-tourist, but reference is made to this phenomenon in the works of several authors: Feifer's *Going Places: The Ways of the Tourist from Imperial Rome to the Present Day*; Urry's *The Tourist Gaze: Leisure and Travel in Contemporary Societies*; and Rojek's *Ways of Escape: Modern Transformations in Leisure and Travel*.

RECOMMENDED BOOKS

Feifer, M. (1985) *Going Places: The Ways of the Tourist from Imperial Rome to the Present Day*. London: Macmillan.

- Rojek, C. (1993) *Ways of Escape: Modern Transformations in Leisure and Travel*. London: Macmillan.
- Urry, J. (1990) *The Tourist Gaze: Leisure and Travel in Contemporary Societies*. London: Sage.

Film and TV Tourism

The term 'film and TV tourism' describes tourism visits prompted by seeing a location on television or at the cinema. This form of tourism also includes visits to places associated with film and television characters or celebrities.

The popular media of film and television have enormous influence on consumers' lives and this influence also extends to tourists' destination choices. Just as literary figures and authors can lure visitors to particular sites (see **literary tourism**), so popular television programmes and successful films can create tourism destinations out of a wide range of locations. This type of tourism has only been researched in recent years with authors referring to this activity as 'movie-induced' or 'film-induced' tourism (Beeton, 2005; Busby and Klug, 2001; Riley, Baker and Van Doren, 1998). Although films and television programmes are equally influential in attracting visitors, they appeal to different types of visitor and the duration of their influence varies. An avid fan of a long-term television soap opera may have a different relationship with its location than a visitor prompted to visit a region because of a recent viewing of a spectacular movie. Similarly, a longstanding television programme such as the UK's *Coronation Street*, which has been broadcast since 1960, has had a much longer span of TV-induced tourism to its location than a film might have.

As suggested in the definition above, film and TV tourism is not simply about visiting locations depicted in the media. There are various themes and forms of film and TV tourism. Beeton (2005) and Busby and Klug (2001) suggest that these can include the following:

On location

- Visiting locations of films or TV programmes (*Monarch of the Glen* country in the Scottish Highlands; *Harry Potter* film locations in the UK).
- Visits to the homes of film or TV celebrities (visits to 'Hollywood Homes of the Stars').

Commercial attractions

- Attractions constructed from film themes (the *Heartbeat Experience*, Whitby, UK).
- Guided tours to various film locations (*Sex and the City* tours in New York; *Sound of Music* tours, Salzburg, Austria).
- Movie tourism packages (*Lord of the Rings* themed package tours).

Stand-in locations

- Tourism visits to places where a film or TV programme is set but not actually filmed

(*Braveheart*, set in Scotland but mainly filmed in Ireland).

Off location

- Film studio tours to view the filming process (Paramount Studios, Los Angeles).
- Film-based theme parks (Universal Studios, Los Angeles).

Events

- Film premieres and festivals (Cannes, Edinburgh, London, Venice).

Armchair travel

- TV travel programmes (*Pole to Pole*, BBC; *The Long Way Down*, BBC).

The diversity of the media-based experiences described above suggests that film and TV tourists are not necessarily a homogeneous group driven by similar motivations. For some visitors, travelling to a specific site may be akin to a pilgrimage – Monty Python fans, for example, have a semi-spiritual experience when visiting Doune Castle in Scotland, the location of *Monty Python and The Holy Grail* (Beeton, 2005). Other visitors may be attracted to a place because of the glamour associated with a specific celebrity or lifestyle portrayed, as in the popular *Sex and The City* tours, which encapsulate the shopping and brunching life of a group of New York women. Others may identify on a more emotional level with a site (for example, the nostalgia associated with visiting locations of the popular 1970 children's film, *The Railway Children*), while others will visit sites out of a general interest, for example visitors to Yorkshire may find themselves wandering in and out of *Heartbeat*, *Last of the Summer Wine* or James Herriot country as part of a wider visit to the county.

Many regions who wish to capitalise on the benefits of media-based tourism have created partnerships between tourism organisations and local film commissions to encourage the use of locations for filming and to publicise the resulting productions. The London film commission, Film London, the London tourism organisation, VisitLondon and various London boroughs have produced and promoted a series of Movie Maps depicting the locations featured in a number of recent films based in the capital. On a similar note, one of the British Tourist Authority's most successful publications was their Movie Map of Britain, which was first produced as a brochure in 1996, later becoming an interactive website.

These examples of destination marketing techniques result in additional tourism activity which, in turn, brings about a series of positive and negative impacts. All tourism activity brings benefits and problems but film and TV tourism is believed to exert a series of effects on destinations that are unique to this form of visitation. Media-based tourism can bring additional income and jobs to an area and in particular can provide opportunities for selling souvenirs/merchandising and spin-off services such as themed tours and services. The profile of an area can be raised, as in the case of the city of Sheffield, which became an unlikely tourism destination in the wake of the popularity of *The Full Monty*. Kim et al. (2007) discuss the role that a Korean TV series entitled *Winter Sonata* played in improving the perception

among Japanese visitors of Korea as a holiday destination. A successful film or TV programme can also assist a country or region in its destination marketing. The New Zealand government was very proactive in using the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy in its national tourism campaigns, and even appointed a 'Minister of the Rings' to maximise the considerable benefits from film-induced tourism (Beeton, 2005). Such success cannot be guaranteed, however, as Frost (2004) illustrates with his case study of the unsuccessful attempts in Victoria, Australia, to capitalise on the 2003 film, *Ned Kelly*.

While some destinations actively intervene to maximise media-related tourism, other regions may be surprised to find themselves at the centre of a film-based tourism boom. As this form of tourism is often difficult to plan, some destinations find that they are subjected to an unsustainable number of visitors. This might result in environmental damage, loss of privacy for the host community or an unwelcome change to the traditional visitor base. The small fishing port of Tobermory on the Isle of Mull, in the Western Isles of Scotland, found itself at the centre of a highly specialised tourism boom when it was used as the setting for the popular children's television programme, *Balamory*. The facilities on this small island were unsuited to large numbers of families, and tourism operators felt disinclined to alter their product to satisfy what might be a fickle market (Connell, 2004, 2005). The lure of film- or TV-based tourism might not last long, so it would be unwise to base long-term planning on what could be a passing trend. The actual filming process itself might also exert impacts on the environment, as in the case of the remote Thai beach used in the filming of *The Beach*, which was bulldozed and widened to accommodate the needs of the production team (Beeton, 2005). The film also opened the once pristine region to endless streams of backpackers keen to thrill to the adventure and romance of their own beach experience.

We have already seen that a film or television programme can bring different types of visitors to a destination, but it could also encourage altered behaviour in tourists. The World Heritage Site of Angkor in Cambodia was used as the location for the computer-game-based adventure film, *Tomb Raider*, and film-induced tourists to the site were found to be climbing on the ancient temple walls in an attempt to emulate the heroine, Lara Croft. This type of media exposure is not seen to be consistent with conservation plans set out for the site (Winter, 2002). Inappropriate visitor behaviour can also extend to the actual removal of part of a site for souvenirs, and street signs and other iconic items have been repeatedly removed from some film and television locations.

Finally, as with **literary tourists**, some visitors to locations may feel some disappointment with the perceived **authenticity** of sites visited. The romantic locations depicted in the very popular film *Notting Hill* would be very difficult to find on the real London street of the same name.

The importance of the simulated image, the fleeting nature of media-based tourism, the blurring of the distinctions between reality and illusion and the role of celebrity have led some commentators to suggest that film and TV tourism is a clear example of **post-tourism**. In contemporary Postmodern culture, where post-tourists operate, real places become commodified and turned into spectacles to be consumed by the ever-present **tourist gaze**, as the visitor views locations as if they were giant cinema screens.

See also: *arts tourism, authenticity, cultural tourism, literary tourism, post-tourism*

FURTHER READING

Sue Beeton's recent text *Film-induced Tourism* is the first sustained exploration of film and TV tourism and is a very useful introduction to the field. A number of case studies are to be found in the journal articles listed below, which cover a range of theoretical and practical issues associated with media-based tourism. Both Tony Reeve's (2003) *The Worldwide Guide to Movie Locations* and the website www.movie-locations.com provide useful details on film-related destinations for the film and TV tourist.

RECOMMENDED BOOKS AND ARTICLES

- Beeton, S. (2005) *Film-induced Tourism*. Clevedon: Channel View.
- Busby, G. and Klug, J. (2001) 'Movie-induced tourism: the challenge of measurement and other issues', *Journal of Vacation Marketing*, 7 (4): 316–32.
- Riley, R., Baker, D. and Van Doren, C. (1998) 'Movie induced tourism', *Annals of Tourism Research*, 25 (4): 919–35.

Destination Management

Destination management refers to the processes of tourism planning, managing and coordination that take place in tourist destinations, usually carried out by a destination management organisation.

Destinations are where much of the visitor's experience of a holiday takes place. It is usually the location where visitors stay and where they carry out many of their sightseeing activities. Simply put, a destination may be a seaside resort, an urban centre or a wilderness area, but destinations vary in terms of geographical and governmental scale and are therefore difficult to define. S.L.J. Smith (1995: 199) presents a set of criteria that may assist in identifying tourism destinations. These criteria include the need for a set of characteristics that provide a sense of identity; an adequate tourism infrastructure; a region that supports more than one community or attraction; the presence of existing attractions or the potential to develop popular attractions; the capacity to support a tourism planning and marketing organisation and, finally, easy accessibility to a large population base.

The destination is vital to the tourism industry as Davidson and Maitland point out:

Destinations are a focus for attention since they stimulate and motivate visits, and are the location in which the major part of the tourist product is produced. As a result, much of the tourism industry is located in destinations, and most of its impacts are experienced in them. (Davidson and Maitland, 1997: 3)

Thus, the tourism destination is host to visitors, the local community and a tourism infrastructure, and the interplay between these can result in a series of impacts, both positive and negative. It is the potential for such impacts which necessitates the careful management of destinations.

Looking more closely at the characteristics of destinations, we can see that they tend to involve a number of core components which are sometimes referred to as the '4As' (Page et al., 2001: 245), namely:

- attractions: either natural, cultural or events
- amenities: hotels, restaurants, shops, tour guides
- access: transport infrastructure
- ancillary services: visitor information, banking, etc.

The diversity of these core components indicates that there is a range of stakeholders involved in a destination and, consequently, destination management is required to ensure that all interests are met, whether they be the needs of the host community, of the tourism industry, of

the public sector or of the tourists themselves. Intervention is also required to ensure consistent standards of quality, the management of impacts and that the destination remains competitive.

The management of destinations is increasingly undertaken by a Destination Management Organisation who, like destinations themselves, can function on varying levels from the national, through the regional and down to the urban or municipal level. Specific examples of DMOs include Tourism Australia (a national organisation), Ibiza Travel (a regional organisation) and Brighton and Hove Visitor and Convention Bureau (a city-based organisation). Destination management organisations can also vary in terms of their structure, as they can be either government tourism departments, private sector organisations or joint public–private partnerships. A recent global survey of DMOs carried out by the World Tourism Organisation found that at the national level, DMOs were much more likely to be either a national government department or agency accountable to national government; at the regional level, they tended to be either a regional/local government department or accountable agency; but at the city level, it was more likely that a DMO would be a public–private partnership. Clearly, each of these structures brings a very different organisational philosophy to the management of destinations and it is interesting to note that the DMOs surveyed by the WTO strongly agreed that the best way to promote and manage destinations was through a public–private partnership (WTO, 2004b).

According to Ritchie and Crouch (2003), a DMO has nine core tasks that it must carry out to manage and promote a destination successfully. These tasks can be defined as internal or external activities. The internal tasks relate to the structures of organizations, administration, budgeting, community relations and publications, whereas the external tasks include visitor services and management, marketing, research and capital management.

In terms of internal tasks required by a DMO, many are purely administrative but the most characteristic is the responsibility for members and for community relations. DMO members are those who have been identified as stakeholders in the local tourism industry and who, in return for an annual fee, can benefit from the assistance of the DMO. These benefits can include networking and training opportunities. As well as working with members, the DMO must also liaise with the wider community, raising the profile of the work of the DMO and educating the public on the importance of tourism within their local community. Such awareness-raising can take the form of inviting residents to become ‘a tourist for the day’ and discover local amenities.

The external managerial tasks identified by Ritchie and Crouch (2003) are where much of a DMO’s efforts are targeted mainly on the areas of marketing, visitor management and resource stewardship.

Marketing is an essential activity for any destination that wishes to remain competitive, and although marketing in tourism terms is often seen to be simply about promotion, successful destination marketing involves a number of key elements that include the identification of key markets, measuring destination awareness and image, developing a clear brand, establishing the destination’s position within key markets, developing logos and promotional and advertising efforts, developing new experiences and identifying pricing (Ritchie and Crouch, 2003: 189). Readers interested in the details of destination marketing should consult Pike’s (2008) *Destination Marketing*.

Visitor management is also key to the management of a destination. This involves managing the visitor experience before, during and after the visit (Shackley, 2004). Before the visit, it is important to provide visitor information and a bookings service through call-centres, visitor information centres and, increasingly, through the use of the internet (see **e-tourism**). Once at the destination, the visitor experience needs to be managed through the provision of appropriate signage, interpretation and pricing strategies designed to facilitate the flow of visitors through the destination. The visitor management approach that is taken will depend on the nature of the destination itself – sensitive, historic or natural environments that attract large numbers of visitors may wish to adopt an approach that limits visitor numbers in high season by differential pricing strategies, restricting access by private transport, using timed entry tickets and providing visitor interpretation that explains how visitor behaviour can impact on the destination. Increasingly, destination smart cards such as the Venice Card or the Budapest Card are being used as an important visitor management tool, allowing visitors to pre-pay for attractions, public transport and parking, and facilitating the management of visitor flow and the maintenance of relationships with visitors, post-visit.

Resource stewardship represents the responsibility that a DMO has for the built, natural and cultural environment. As identified above, much of the impact brought about by tourism is experienced in the destination itself, whether it be pollution, erosion and the depletion of species in natural environments, damage to historic buildings and overloaded infrastructures in urban centres, or the impacts on religion, value systems, arts and crafts in the socio-cultural landscape. Measures taken by destinations to address these issues include environmental impact assessments (EIAs), the creation of specific carrying capacities for destinations, setting limits of acceptable change within the environment (LACs) and zoning (see **sustainable tourism** for further discussion on these measures).

As tourism continues to grow on a global scale, it is increasingly important that destinations are managed to protect the resources on which tourism depends, to manage the needs and expectations of a diverse range of stakeholders and to ensure a good visitor experience.

See also: *e-tourism, sustainable tourism, urban tourism*

FURTHER READING

Further reading in the field of destination management could be usefully pursued within Papatheodorou's 2007 text, *Managing Tourism Destinations*. The World Tourism Organisation's *Practical Guide to Destination Management* is, as it suggests in the title, a good, practical resource.

RECOMMENDED BOOKS AND ARTICLES

Papatheodorou, A. (ed.) (2007) *Managing Tourism Destinations*. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar.
Pike, S. (2008) *Destination Marketing*. London: Butterworth-Heinemann.

Ritchie, J.R.B. and Crouch, G.I. (2003) *The Competitive Destination*. Wallingford: CABI.
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Authenticity

Authenticity in tourism can be defined as the value that tourists and hosts place on the development and consumption of what are perceived to be genuine cultural events, products and experiences.

Discussions of authenticity are common in the literature of tourism studies and have been central to explorations of the social and cultural impacts of tourism since the American anthropologist Dean MacCannell first published his influential text *The Tourist* in 1976. The increasing influence of the tourism industry, the greater ease of travel and ever-widening range of visited places has increased the urgency of debates on the impacts of tourism on the authenticity of cultures. These debates focus on the ways in which tourism has impacted on the authenticity of:

- the tourists' experience of places and culture
- the culture of the hosts themselves
- the nature of the host–guest relationship
- the production of cultural objects and events consumed (but not necessarily exclusively) by tourists.

The assumption is that tourism and the presence of tourists results in a loss of genuine real culture, to be replaced by trivial, commodified events, products and experiences that debase both the producer and the consumer. Of course, what is 'authentic', 'real' or 'genuine' is difficult to define as these are relative terms that are not shared among the world's cultures. Consequently, three different perspectives on authenticity and its relevance to tourism have emerged within the literature of tourism studies, namely:

1. 'objective authenticity' – an externally verified truth
2. 'constructive authenticity' – an emergent form of authenticity
3. 'existential authenticity' – an approach to the genuine that takes into account the individual's own experience (Cohen, 1988; Jamal and Hill, 2002; Wang, 1999).

Objective authenticity assumes that genuine touristic experience and products exist, can be verified as such, but are perhaps less easy to find in contemporary society. Importance is placed on objects made from what we consider to be authentic materials and by indigenous craftspeople or on events and rituals that we perceive as being traditional expressions of genuine cultures. This view of authenticity concentrates on original objects that provide genuine touristic experiences for those who recognise the

- authenticating signs. Cohen cites the work of Trilling (1972), who traces the provenance of the word 'authenticity' in this context to the world of museums where experts authenticate objects using a range of strict criteria (Cohen, 1988: 374). Objects displayed in museums and, importantly, the information provided on these objects, are generally perceived by the visitor to be genuine and meticulously researched. Of course,
- (1) the objectivity and authority of the museum and museum curator are now no longer taken at face value and museums are seen as products of the societies that support them: a selective treasure house reflecting past and contemporary power relations (Bennett, 1995; Macdonald and Fyfe, 1996). However, the idea that objective facts can be known about objects or historical events is still central to the work of scientists, anthropologists and archaeologists.

In *The Tourist* (1976), Dean MacCannell suggests that authenticity is a characteristic of pre-modern or primitive societies and that modern tourists are on a pilgrimage to seek that lost innocence. Our contemporary lives have alienated us from the genuine experiences and relationships experienced by our ancestors. Therefore, instead of simply living our own lives, we are increasingly consuming experiences and products that are based on other lives and times and created by the **heritage tourism** industries. Thus:

[t]he modernisation of work relations, history and nature detaches these from their traditional roots and transforms them into cultural productions and experiences ... Modern Man is losing his attachments to the work bench, the neighborhood, the town, the family, which he once called 'his own' but, at the same time, he is developing an interest in the 'real life' of others. (MacCannell, 1976: 91)

Authenticity is essentially a modern concern of the industrialised West (Cohen, 1988: 373). The Romantic Movement of the eighteenth century mourned the triumph of science and the loss of innocence brought about by the industrial revolution and saw nature and the pre-modern as a source of genuine, unadulterated culture. MacCannell (1976) suggests that 'primitive' remote communities have no concept of authenticity and consequently have not yet developed a system of 'front and back stage' to protect their privacy. Once visitors begin to arrive, communities engage in 'staged authenticity', setting up contrived events to satisfy their guests' desires for authentic cultural manifestations. Meanwhile, back-stage, real life continues unadulterated. Back-stage regions thus become holy grails for adventurous independent travellers but, MacCannell suggests, as outsiders, they will never gain entry. Conversely, the work of Boorstin (1964) suggests that tourists are on a deliberate search for 'pseudo-events' and superficial experiences and that they are responsible for the inauthenticity of the tourism industry.

Constructive authenticity argues that reality is not an elusive entity but, instead, a constructed phenomenon. Reality is created in our own minds, which are influenced by our personal worldviews and external social, cultural and political factors. This suggests that ideas of what is authentic are not static but emerge over time and are relative and negotiated. Constructive authenticity is not only formed within the individual's mind but

- (2) is also created and shared within communities. In their work entitled *The Invention of Tradition* (1983), Hobsbawm and Ranger explore how seemingly ancient traditions are created for contemporary purposes (including tourism) and very quickly become accepted as part of a community's or nation's history. The British Coronation ceremony, the Romantic imagery of Wales and the Scottish Highlands and the symbols of nationhood (for example, flags and national anthems) have all been deliberately, and relatively recently, created to encourage patriotism, loyalty or even subservience and yet are considered to be authentic from both the community and the visitor perspective (Hobsbawm and Ranger, 1983).

The tourism industry and its associated media are involved in the business of constructing authenticity as part of the product presented to visitors. Such versions of reality become accepted by tourists as part of the package of holiday experiences, and the power of the industry, the media and other stakeholders in creating attractive versions of reality is considerable. Indeed, John Urry talks of the post-tourist (Urry, 1990/2002) who actively enjoys the artifice of staged authenticity while being aware that this is a game to be played (see **post-tourism**).

- Existential authenticity suggests that the individual creates a sense of truth within him or herself (Hughes, 1995; Wang, 1999). The demands of everyday life have led to concerns that we are losing sight of our true selves – the simpler, more playful, natural selves that are repressed by work and responsibilities. The rituals of tourism include relaxation, freedom from constraint and a simpler, more pared-down routine based on sensual enjoyment. Therefore, tourism itself can be seen not as a corrupting and commodifying influence but as a way of being that is genuine and natural. Tourists involved in active participation rather than observation are more likely to experience this sense of existential authenticity. Ooi (2002) notes that there is more chance of this happening if cultural mediators, such as tour guides, absent themselves and allow the tourists to feel they are both part of the local community and experiencing culture bodily. Having a sense of performing within a culture and creatively adjusting the body to the shape of a dance, for example, will create a sense of existential authenticity (Daniel, 1996).
- (3)

There may be few opportunities and places within our daily lives to experience such existential authenticity and so those environments which do offer such liberation have become increasingly prized. Tourism activities that involve a close association with the countryside such as camping or hiking are therefore popular because they allow individuals to test themselves and rediscover their essential selves. These tourists are seeking authenticity within themselves rather than in the places or objects that they encounter. Wang (1999) suggests that existential authenticity can also be experienced within close family relationships which become more genuine and binding in tourism's playful environments. Other relationships can be equally genuine, however – the experience of being with a like-minded group is akin to a pilgrimage or rite of passage, with the places and events being of secondary importance.

Authenticity is, therefore, a complex and socially constructed concept that is problematic and

highly emotive when applied to tourism. It has been suggested that the post-tourist is unconcerned with authenticity which has become an outmoded concept (Urry, 1990/2002). However, the wide range of **ecotourism** and special interest tourism products and businesses that base themselves on authentic, genuine experiences suggest that the concept is still attractive to consumers.

See also: heritage tourism, post-tourism, tourist gaze

FURTHER READING

Dean MacCannell's seminal text *The Tourist* (1976) is a useful starting point for studies of authenticity as is Eric Cohen's work (1988) and that of Boorstin (1964). More recent works include that of Wang (1999) and Jamal and Hill (2002) who provide comprehensive overviews of the issues outlined above.

RECOMMENDED BOOKS AND ARTICLES

- Boorstin, D. (1964) *The Image: A Guide to Pseudo Events in America*. New York: Harper & Row.
- Cohen, C. (1988) 'Authenticity and commoditisation in tourism', *Annals of Tourism Research*, 15: 371–86.
- Jamal, T. and Hill, S. (2002) 'The home and the world: (post)touristic spaces of (in)authenticity', in G. Dann (ed.), *The Tourist as Metaphor of the Social World*. Wallingford: CABI. pp. 77–107.
- MacCannell, D. (1976) *The Tourist: A New Theory of the Leisure Class*. London: MacMillan.
- Wang, N. (1999) 'Rethinking authenticity in tourism experience', *Annals of Tourism Research*, 26 (2): 349–70.